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need for a media centre completely. In regards to the online console idea, Kutaragi says, "The design concept of the Cell processor is the network processor. When the PS3 was introduced last year, the network environment was not ready for a net-based game console. Now it has become possible, so why not enter?"

An HD-toting, movie-playing Wii successor is in the works too (it *had* to be). It will come with a much-needed hard drive to store video and other media, and perhaps even eliminate one of the more harebrained flaws in the console—the lack of an Ethernet port!

But will you ride this console wave?

India And The Console

According to a report by the NPD Group, in April this year, the Xbox 360 sold around 174,000 units in North America, and the PS3 sold 82,000. In India, selling even 174 would probably qualify as a good month. In all honesty, none of India's gaming numbers could come even close to those for the US or Europe—gaming in general is still a very new concept to India. Our parents still can't figure out why we'd want to blow up as

much as Rs 40,000 (PS3) for something that "just plays games." Your PC plays games, they'll say—use that.

It's sad that India isn't thought of too much in the matter of consoles. Xbox Live—integral to the 360 experience—hasn't officially launched for India yet, and you won't be able to access paid content on the PlayStation Network either. We're still a growing name in the PC gaming arena; it'll be a while yet before we're taken seriously in the console department. Jesse Rapczak, Vice President, Production at the Noida-based Exigent Studios has a vision: In an interview with Flame War Advance, he says: "The real question is, what's going to happen to consoles when India and China become world powers in gaming? Because, the console market is strictly geared at U.S., Europe and Japan... The numbers say that console gaming is going to go down. And PC, online and mobile gaming is on the rise, and all this will happen in India and China over the next five years. Come 2010, some people might not be playing game consoles."

India affecting the future of the console? Powerful thought, that. ☒

Immersed In An Alternative Reality

The future of games and other stories

The gaming industry works very closely with the graphics card industry, in fact, drives it. The latest games strain current-generation hardware and force new products from GPU manufacturers. The same way, these manufacturers are facilitators for the gaming industry.

Computer games are getting closer and closer to the real thing, and we feel this is a good thing. People want to escape from reality, and that escapism is the number one reason for indulging in gaming. But gamers want *realism*, whether it's weather effects, facial expressions, explosions, physics, shadows, and terrain deformation. Then there's all the realism demanded by first person shooter lovers revolving around realistic weapon models and effects—flaming gun barrels, screaming ricochets, realistic body damage and gore effects etc.

A contradiction? The simple fact is that games give you a chance to live out an alternative personality without fear of consequences. You can be a warrior, a spy, a pilot, a playboy, an assassin or even a cricketer, all within the safe confines of your home. You're in control of your life—basically something every individual craves, but doesn't necessarily get.

Perhaps the best shot in the arm for realism in games is DX 10. In fact one of the biggest reasons for gamers to shift to Windows Vista is the upcoming DX 10 games. The current generation of graphics hardware is also up to the task, and we're already seeing three times the rendering power from previous generation cards, NVIDIA's 8800GTX (128 shader units) and the ATI X2900 series (320 shader processors) promise to bring lifelike realism in games.

